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MAHATMA GANDHI UNIVERSITY, KOTTAYAM
MGU-UGP (Honours) – Fifth Semester Examination, October 2026
MG5DSEENG307 – PARTITION LITERATURE

Duration: 2 Hours **Maximum Marks: 70**

Scheme of valuation

PART A
MCQ Answer all Questions. Each question carries 1 mark.

1. b). Control, integration and autonomy [U] / [CO1]
2. b). It divided Kurdistan between Iraq and Turkey [U] / [CO1]
3. c) Mangoes and jackfruits. [An] / [CO2]
4. d) Amrit Lehran. [U] / [CO2]
5. d) At the Ahmedabad railway station. [K] / [CO2]
6. b) Their families couldn't afford to retrieve them. [K] / [CO3]
7. c). Remain in India despite internal conflict [U] / [CO3]
8. b) The tension between abstract national boundaries and lived, embodied attachment to place [U] / [CO3]
9. a). Mano Majra [K] / [CO4]
10. c). Muslim [K] / [CO4]

[1x10 = 10]

PART B
Answer any 6 questions. Each question carries 5 marks.

11. Ayesha is revealed to have been Veero, a Sikh woman who survived the violence and threat of sexual assault during Partition - later lives in Pakistan under a new religious identity and appears to have built a settled life with her son - the past remains present through her silence, gestures and memories - her son becomes influenced by religious extremism - her tragic decision to jump into a well echoes the fate of women who faced unbearable pressure during Partition. Veero/Ayesha's story demonstrates that Partition trauma does not end with migration or the creation of borders - it continues to shape memory, identity and later generations - it also exposes patriarchal ideas of honour and the silencing of women's experiences. [U] / [CO1]

12. Lajo is abducted during Partition and later recovered. Sunderlal publicly advocates that recovered women should be accepted back into their families. Yet, instead of restoring an ordinary, intimate relationship with Lajo, he idealises her as a goddess. This apparently respectful attitude becomes problematic because it turns Lajo into a symbol of purity, sacrifice and community honour rather than recognising her as a person with her own feelings and traumatic experiences – his idealisation creates emotional distance and makes it difficult for Lajo to speak about what happened to her - criticises patriarchal attitudes that silence women even when they are publicly honoured. [U] / [CO1]

13. Police firing contributes to the atmosphere of fear, violence and insecurity - shows ordinary people caught in events they cannot control - highlights the human cost of political or communal unrest. Alongside the images of corpses and vultures, the firing suggests a society in which death and violence have entered everyday life - image criticises violence and narrow nationalism - directs attention to the vulnerability and shared humanity of common people. [An] / [CO2]

14. The image of an entombed minaret can be read as a sign that cultural, religious and communal life has been buried or obstructed by violence. A minaret normally belongs to a living community and is associated with worship and public presence; its entombment suggests the silencing of that community and the destruction of familiar spaces. [An] / [CO2]
15. Partition- a continuing experience- not a closed historical event. The film avoids a simple, happy resolution. Salim Mirza and his family-financial hardship, social suspicion and insecurity as Muslims who remain in India after Partition. Salim is suspected and humiliated because of his links with relatives in Pakistan - communal mistrust enters ordinary life - family's decision to migrate arises from accumulated pressure and disappointment - film does not offer an easy solution to these problems- in the end, however, Salim encounters young people protesting for justice and decides to remain in India and join their struggle - ending acknowledges continuing uncertainty and injustice. - does not erase the trauma or guarantee success - offers cautious hope through collective action, secular values and the possibility of rebuilding belonging - film links personal suffering with larger historical forces while suggesting that people can respond through resistance and civic commitment. [U]/ [CO3]
16. Separation from biological family during Partition - Raised by Shakur and Zenab as Altaf - Emotional bonds with foster family - Return to biological family; renamed Yashpal - Conflict between biological and acquired identity - Religion as a marker of belonging - Child's innocence amid communal divisions - Love and affection beyond religious boundaries - Emotional trauma caused by Partition. [U] / [CO3]
17. Simple, direct and accessible language - Ordinary situations and everyday experiences - Child's confusion and parental grief - Affection and care shown by Shakur and Zenab - Realistic portrayal of Partition's impact - Restrained narration; absence of melodrama - Humane representation across religious divisions - Irony of communal hatred - Identity, displacement, motherhood, compassion and trauma. [U] / [CO3]
18. Iqbal – arrested- suspicion of murder of the moneylender. Reflects the arbitrary nature of colonial policing- how individuals- victims of suspicion and circumstance- cannot immediately intervene- village's communal crisis - failure of the legal system to ensure justice. [A] / [CO4]
19. Partition divides people according to religion. Mano Majra - peaceful coexistence. Political boundaries disrupt long-standing relationships. Religious identity - important than shared humanity- the artificiality and tragic consequences of communal divisions. The peaceful routine of Mano Majra is disturbed - arrival of the ghost train. The villagers' fear and suspicion- communal violence spreads across the border. The authorities - evacuation of Mano Majra's Muslim residents to a refugee camp. The planned attack on the train carrying Muslim refugees - how religious identity determines who becomes a target. Juggut Singh risks his life - humanity can transcend communal divisions. [K] / [CO4]

[5x6 = 30]

PART C
Answer any 2 questions. Each question carries 15 marks.

20. The essay "A Will to Say or Unsay: Female Silences and Discursive Interventions in Partition Narratives" by Parvinder Mehta explores the complex relationship between silence, trauma, memory and representation in narratives of the Partition of India. To develop her argument, Mehta analyses a range of literary and cinematic texts that deal with Partition and its aftermath. These include Rajinder Singh Bedi's short story "Lajwanti", Sabiha Sumar's film *Khamosh Pani* (*Silent Waters*) and Shauna Singh Baldwin's novel *What the Body Remembers*. Conventional Partition histories: politics, independence and migration - Marginalisation of women's experiences - Abduction, sexual violence, forced migration and loss - Patriarchy, honour and control over women's bodies - *Lajwanti:* Lajo's abduction and return - Sunderlal's public advocacy for

recovered women - Idealisation of Lajo as a goddess - Woman as symbol rather than individual - Silence; lack of emotional intimacy and agency - *Silent Waters*: Veero's transformation into Ayesha - Past trauma and religious extremism - Identity, memory and patriarchal control - Silence and tragic ending - *What the Body Remembers*: women's bodily and domestic experiences - Gendered power and communal violence - Trauma through memory, gesture and silence - Recovery of marginalised voices - Silence as fear, shame, repression or resistance - Women's agency and survival - Challenge to official historical narratives - Gendered cost of Partition - Women's experiences essential to understanding Partition. [U] / [CO1]

21. Taslima Nasrin; Partition and division of Bengal - Homeland, memory and belonging - Mangoes, jackfruits, sunlight, rain and harvest festivals - Familiar landscape and cultural roots - Emotional attachment to place - Forced movement and separation from home - Political division and communal hostility - Uprooting and unfamiliar places - Instability, insecurity and loss - Physical movement versus emotional belonging - Flower garden invaded by a wild bull - Destruction of peace and harmony - Broken dreams and separated people - Land reaching towards separated people - Longing for reunion - Political maps versus lived experience - Borders unable to erase language, customs and memories - New location without a sense of home - Disruption of cultural continuity - Physical, emotional and cultural consequences of displacement - Lasting effects of Partition; longing for reunion beyond borders.

[An] / [CO2]

22. Saadat Hasan Manto; Partition of India - Exchange of asylum inmates between India and Pakistan - Division of the subcontinent; political absurdity - Mental asylum as a miniature of the divided subcontinent - Bishan Singh's repeated question about Toba Tek Singh - Attachment to birthplace, memory and identity - Confusion over national boundaries - Personal belonging versus political classification - Fractured speech and confusion among inmates - Irrationality of political decisions -"Sane" authorities versus "mad" inmates - Criticism of state power and arbitrary divisions - Bishan Singh in the no-man's-land between India and Pakistan - Neither country; absence of secure belonging - Ending as a symbol of displacement and exclusion - Specific historical context of Partition - Universal themes of borders, identity, displacement and home - State-imposed categories versus human experience - Relevance beyond 1947; forced migration and territorial conflict - Human cost of artificial boundaries - Memory and belonging beyond political maps

[U] / [CO3]

23. Mano Majra initially represents peaceful coexistence among religious communities. Displacement connected to different aspects like- Historical disruption-Partition destroys the village's traditional harmony. Forced migration-Trains carrying dead bodies reveal the brutality of communal violence. Loss of home- Refugees experience fear, uncertainty, and separation from familiar places. Communal polarization-Religious identity replaces earlier bonds of friendship and peaceful co-existence. Human suffering- Ordinary villagers become victims of political decisions and collective hatred. The railway- symbol travel and connection- now a vehicle of death. Khushwant Singh - displacement - physical uprooting and the destruction of social trust and human relationships. [A] / [CO4]

[15x2 = 30]